Test-day strategy (ASWB Clinical, 2026 format)

The exam in numbers

Fact	Detail
Questions	122: 110 scored + 12 unscored pretest, mixed in and unmarked
Sections	2 sections of 61; up to 2 hours each; unused time does not carry over
Break	One optional break of up to 10 minutes after Section 1; extra minutes come off exam time
Section 1	Locked once you finish it; you can move freely within a section
Options	3 or 4, one correct; no "all of the above"
Scoring	Pass/fail; about 66-78 correct of 110, depending on the form; no guessing penalty, so answer every item
Pace	About 2 minutes per item
Tools	Flag, highlight, strike-through, scratch pad, zoom to 200%, high contrast
Arrival	30 minutes early; two IDs whose names match your authorization

The six-step routine for every item

1. **Read the last sentence first.** Find the qualifier and name the task: order (FIRST/NEXT), compare (BEST/MOST), interpret (MOST likely) or single answer (none).
2. **Read the stem.** Note the stage (intake, after assessment, sixth session), who the client is, and any safety, legal or medical flag.
3. **Predict** the answer before looking at the options.
4. **Eliminate by name.** Give each wrong option a flaw: wrong time, skips assessment, overrides choice, ignores risk, outside the role.
5. **Break ties** with the qualifier: what must come first, what answers this exact question, what a peer-review panel would defend.
6. **Commit, flag if unsure, move on.** Change an answer only for a reason.

Qualifier cheat sheet

Word	Key is...	Usual trap
FIRST	The step everything else depends on (safety, assessment, consent, mandate)	A good step that belongs later
NEXT	One step after what the stem says was done	Repeating the done step; jumping ahead
BEST / **MOST** appropriate	The most direct, effective, client-centered option	True but aimed at a different problem
MOST likely	The reading that fits every fact	A near-miss that fails one detail
none	The only correct option	Options that are simply wrong

Priority order when principles collide

Imminent safety, then legal mandate, then core ethics, then assess before intervening, then start where the client is, then least restrictive, then agency policy, then worker preference.

The 13 trap labels (the app tracks yours)

Right action, wrong time · Skips assessment · Overrides the client's choice · Outside the social work role · Ignores risk · Hands off too soon · Boundary slip or collusion · Too directive · Wrong model or concept · Near-miss diagnosis · Misreads law or ethics · Good but not best · Misuses the technique

Mindset rules

- Answer as the **textbook social worker**: ethical, competent, resourced, with time to do it right. Not your agency.
- **Use only the stem's facts**, and use all of them. Don't add a plan, a substance or abuse that isn't there.
- **Don't guess by shape.** "Explore" isn't always right, "refer" isn't always wrong, and the middle option isn't automatically best.
- The exam is national: answer from the NASW Code and federal law, not California rules.
- There are no patterns in answer letters, difficulty or order.

Pacing plan (per section)

Time used	Aim to be at
30 minutes	about item 15
1 hour	about item 30
1 hour 30 minutes	about item 45
1 hour 50 minutes	all 61 answered; review flags

Recall items go fast; bank that time for long vignettes. Never leave an item blank.

The week of and the day of

- Last 2 days: light review only (sheets, missed-question takeaways). No full practice exam in the last 2 days.
- Take the break: stand, drink water, eat a snack. Section 2 starts fresh.
- If you get stuck: reread the last sentence, find the qualifier, eliminate one option, pick, flag, move.
- ASWB offers registered candidates a free test-mindset program; ask about it when you register.

Sources: ASWB 2026 Social Work Licensing Exam Guidebook; ASWB exam scoring page; this app's item standard (ITEM_SPEC v1.1). Practice items in this app are original, not ASWB questions.